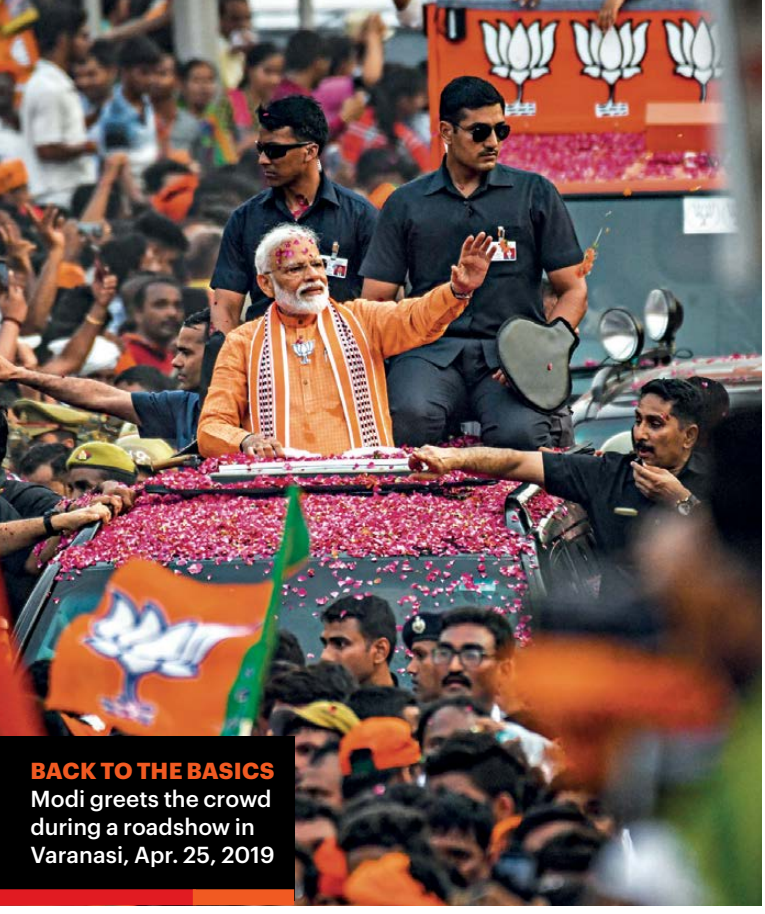


BACK TO THE BASICS Modi greets the crowd during a roadshow in Varanasi, Apr. 25, 2019

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

government as reformist intervention. Yet not all internal challenges were mastered. Manipur's prolonged unrest exposed governance failures in conflict resolution. The Citizenship Amendment Act triggered nationwide protests, culminating in the Delhi riots, a reminder that social cohesion remained fragile in a rapidly changing India.

Modi's tenure also marked the hardening of India's strategic posture. After the Uri terror attack in 2016, India conducted surgical strikes across the Line of Control. Following Pulwama in 2019, the Balakot airstrikes marked the first deep aerial incursion into Pakistan since 1971. More recently in 2025, after the Pahalgam terror attack, Modi launched Operation Sindoor, resulting in the sixth Indo-Pakistan war after India carried out aerial strikes on key targets in the heart of Pakistan. Relations with China proved more complex. The 2020 Galwan clashes shattered decades-old assumptions about border stability. Modi responded with military reinforcement, economic pushback and diplomatic recalibration.

Modi's overall foreign policy departed from traditional non-alignment and cautious multilateralism by embracing multi-alignments anchored in national interest rather than ideological hesitation. India deepened ties with the US while preserving strategic autonomy, strengthened the Quad, engaged the Gulf, and expanded influence in Africa and the Indo-Pacific. Modi projected India as a civilisational power with global responsibility by successfully hosting the G20, shaping climate finance debates, and acting as the voice of the Global South. But Donald Trump's return to American presidency in 2025 shook the foundations of India's growing relations with America, and ties remained frayed till the end of 2025.

When it came to politics, Modi and his chief strategist Amit Shah transformed the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) into an election-winning machine and a vote-maximising behemoth. Booth management, micro-targeting, welfare delivery, narrative control and relentless campaigning saw the BJP become not just the world's largest political party on paper, but the most formidable in practice. The results were historic. Modi's emphatic re-election in 2019, followed by a third consecutive victory in 2024, made him the first prime minister since Jawaharlal Nehru to win three successive mandates.

If India voted Modi back thrice, it was not because voters agreed with every decision, but because they trusted his intent, his energy, his capacity to act and were inspired by his futurist vision of a Viksit Bharat by 2047. As the prime minister put it, "Today, every person knows Modi will not back down from his duty. The faith of the poor keeps me going." Yet the 2024 general election result was a rude reminder to the BJP that power is never a permanent entitlement. While it emerged as the single largest party, the BJP fell short of a majority, forcing a return to alliance arithmetic at the Centre. The party learnt it lessons fast, and recovery was swift. By 2025, the BJP registered commanding victories in Maharashtra, Haryana, Delhi and Bihar, underscoring both organisational resilience and Modi's enduring electoral pull.

INDIA DID NOT JUST CHANGE GOVERNMENTS, IT CHANGED GEARS, SIGNALLING THE MAKING OF THE SECOND REPUBLIC

Beyond politics and policy, the decade also produced moments of collective pride. Neeraj Chopra's Olympic gold in 2021 rewrote India's athletic history. Shooter Manu Bhaker's double Olympic medals reinforced a new sporting confidence. India's triumph in the T20 World Cup revived cricketing supremacy. In space, India's moon landing announced technological self-belief to the world. India moved forward in other unexpected ways: homosexuality was decriminalised, signalling a quiet but significant shift in social attitudes that was often led by the judiciary, but embraced by a changing society.

So, what did the Modi decade mean for India? It redefined welfare delivery, pushed nationalism, furthered national interests, and asserted India's ambitions at home and abroad. It also sharpened polarities, tested federalism, and left some promises unfulfilled. History will debate Modi's legacy for decades. But there is little doubt that between 2015 and 2025, India did not merely change governments, it changed gears, signalling the making of the Second Republic. ■